national independence to some form of socialism. Cuba's was one of them.

Socialist revolutions, then, occurred in societies with very little industry: Russia, China, Cuba, and other Third World countries in Africa, Asia, and Latin America. "As a consequence of the economic realities of Third World societies, developing the productive forces has become the central goal of transition to socialism," Vilas wrote. Socialism became no more than "a species of left-wing developmentalism, a method for accelerating modernization."

In addition, the economic backwardness of Third World revolutionary countries forced them to seek economic support from outside. This "outside" became, inevitably, given the geo-political realities of the twentieth century, the USSR. Reliance on the USSR and the Council for Mutual Economic Assistance (COMECON) became "the central element in the conceptualization of these regimes as 'socialist,' in an epoch in which the USSR was waging an aggressive political competition with U.S. expansion in the Third World. From this point onward, the socialist-oriented, or at least non-capitalist, road that these countries were walking was more a function of the friends they could gather abroad than of the policies they were pushing at home. Or to put it a different way, the political classification of Third World regimes become more an issue of international politics than of political economy. Not infrequently, such 'socialist-oriented' regimes were highly authoritarian, and their only connection to socialism was their orientation toward the foreign policies of the Soviet Union."[19]

Latin American Attitudes

"Fidel Castro is a symbol," one of my Cuban colleagues tried to explain in a talk at a college in Maine a few years ago. For many in Latin America and elsewhere, he is a symbol of speaking truth to power. When he stood up at the Group of 77 "South Summit" in 2000 and attacked neoliberal economic policies and corporate globalization – what he called "the neoliberal race to catastrophe" – for the poverty and